

<Redacted_original_hostname> **Endpoint Hardening Report**
IAM Baseline, Software Inventory, and Attack Surface Reduction
Date: 2026-05-05 to 2026-05-08
System: HP Windows Laptop
Endpoint Name: IF-WIN-HP01
Project: IronForge Manufacturing Lab / Endpoint Hardening

Public Release / Redaction Note

Public artifacts were redacted to remove personal account details, local usernames, original hostnames, and unnecessary environment identifiers while preserving control-validation evidence.

1.Executive Summary

<Redacted_original_hostname> was baselined, renamed to IF-WIN-HP01, reviewed for local IAM exposure, updated through a controlled network reconnection, and reduced for non-essential application attack surface. Initial issues included inaccurate system time, unavailable Local Security Policy console, stale protection status due to offline state, and numerous consumer/gaming applications. The device is now progressing through Defender, firewall, update, and remote access readiness validation.

Stage 01: IAM and Security Baseline

Initial baseline collection was performed while the endpoint was offline. Local user accounts, administrator group membership, built-in Administrator status, account policy settings, and current user context were captured as baseline IAM artifacts.

A system time discrepancy was observed during offline collection and documented before correction. After correcting the system date/time, key IAM artifacts were re-run to preserve accurate timestamps and support audit reliability.

Local Security Policy was unavailable through secpol.msc, likely due to Windows edition limitations. As an alternate baseline method, account policy information was captured using net accounts.

The built-in Administrator account remained disabled. However, the account showed Password required: No, which was documented as a potential elevated-access risk if the account were later enabled without correction. No enablement was performed.

Windows Security initially showed action needed for virus and threat protection, likely due to stale protection status while offline. After controlled reconnection to trusted Wi-Fi for update validation, Windows Security returned to a no-action-needed state. A third-party endpoint security product presented an identity/data breach prompt requesting sensitive personal information; no SSN or personal data was entered, and the prompt was documented as vendor notification/upsell activity outside the endpoint hardening scope.

Windows Hello PIN was enabled and retained as the recommended local sign-in method. Facial recognition and fingerprint options were unavailable, and no password change was performed through the GUI because the password option was not visible in Sign-in options.

Stage 01 Result: IAM baseline, time correction, Windows Security validation, and sign-in option review were completed. Built-in Administrator remained disabled, and Windows Security returned to a no-action-needed state after controlled update validation.

Stage 02: Device Rename and Software Inventory

Original device name: <redacted_original_hostname>

Endpoint renamed from original hostname to IF-WIN-HP01 for IronForge Manufacturing lab integration. Rename supports asset identification, documentation consistency, and future remote administration planning.

Software inventory baseline successfully generated using PowerShell after WMIC method returned invalid GET expression. Inventory file creation, population, and timestamps verified through CLI review.

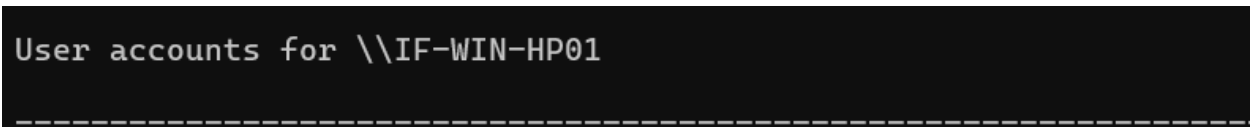


Figure 1: Local user enumeration after endpoint rename to IF-WIN-HP01, validating device identity and capturing baseline account presence for IAM hardening documentation.

Software Inventory Baseline

Date: 2026-05-07

Baseline files created:

- installed_apps_baseline.csv
- installed_apps64_bit.csv

Stage 03: Reduce unnecessary software and potential attack surface without risking system stability.

Removal candidates included non-essential consumer applications, gaming platforms, promotional utilities, unused cloud-storage trials, browser helper tools, optimizer/cleaner utilities, duplicate toolbars, and printer/vendor utilities not required for the endpoint’s intended use.

Removal guardrails were applied to avoid impacting system stability. Driver packages, Microsoft dependencies, Office components, Edge WebView2, Visual C++ runtimes, .NET, firmware/BIOS tools, networking components, touchpad drivers, Windows Security, and Windows Update components were retained.

Rollback Control:

Create restore point before removals.

Restore point name: Pre-Phase1-App-Removal

Application Removal Summary

Batch	Removed Category	Removal Method	Validation
Batch 1	Consumer games, promotional utility	GUI uninstall	Reboot and Installed Apps review
Batch 2	Game launchers, browser helper utility, entertainment apps	GUI uninstall	Reboot, GUI review, stale-entry check

Non-essential software was removed in two controlled batches using Windows Settings > Apps > Installed Apps. Removal candidates included consumer gaming applications, game launchers, promotional utilities, browser helper tools, and unused cloud-storage trial software. Essential system components, drivers, Microsoft dependencies, Office components, Edge WebView2, Visual C++ runtimes, .NET components, firmware/BIOS tools, networking components, touchpad drivers, Windows Security, and Windows Update components were retained.

After each removal batch, the endpoint was rebooted and the Installed Apps GUI was reviewed to confirm removal status. Some residual or stale app entries remained temporarily visible after uninstall, requiring post-reboot validation before being treated as fully removed.

Batch 1 Reboot Validation

After the first reboot, seven applications had been removed through the GUI. Some linked game entries remained visible in Installed Apps, while other non-essential applications appeared absent.

Batch 2 Removal Log

Batch 2 followed the same removal guardrails. Essential system components, drivers, Microsoft dependencies, and update/security components were not removed.

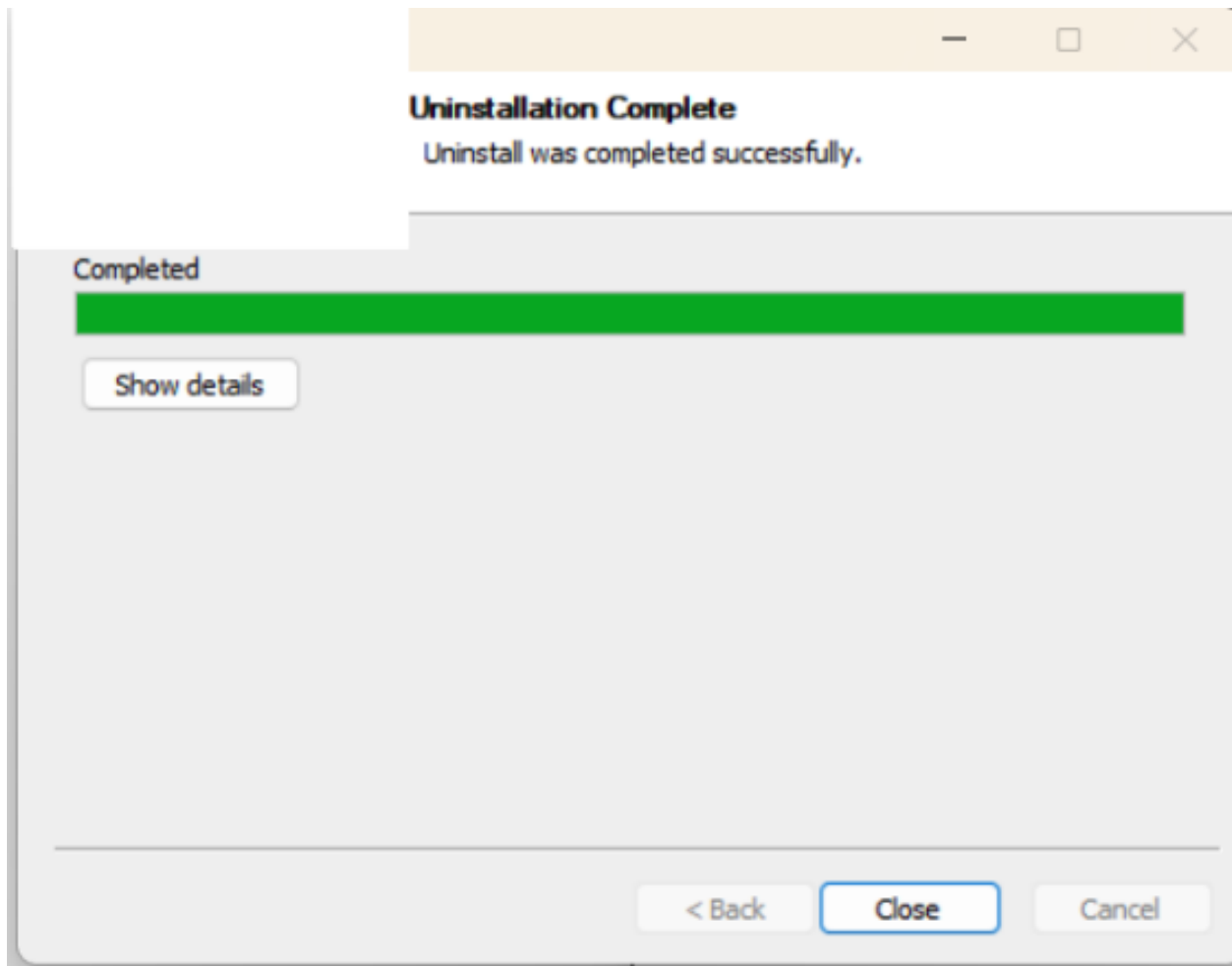


Figure 2: Non-essential application uninstall completion captured during Batch 2 application removal, supporting attack surface reduction and validation of consumer software removal.Batch 2 Reboot Validation

After the second reboot some linked game entries still appeared temporarily, but uninstall links returned “link not found,” indicating residual/stale app entries rather than active installed applications. Additional validation remained pending.

Batch 2 Notes

- Removal method for all listed applications: Windows Settings > Apps > Installed Apps
- Screenshots were captured for private evidence retention.
- Additional consumer gaming applications, game launchers, browser helper utilities, and entertainment-related applications were removed through GUI uninstall.
- A low-value browser/security companion utility was removed due to potential unwanted behavior or browser modification risk.
- Some application entries appeared gone through the GUI, with reboot validation recommended.
- One game launcher required post-reboot validation because linked application entries may remain visible until refresh/reboot.
- Residual or stale entries were documented and marked for additional validation where uninstall links were no longer available. User/admin privilege review

PowerShell

- net user <redacted_user>

```

Comment
User's comment
Country/region code          000 (System Default)
Account active                Yes
Account expires               Never

Password last set             12/25/2021 10:28:39 AM
Password expires              Never
Password changeable           12/25/2021 10:28:39 AM
Password required              Yes
User may change password       Yes

Workstations allowed          All
Logon script
User profile
Home directory
Last logon                    Never

Logon hours allowed            All

Local Group Memberships        *Administrators      *Users
Global Group memberships       *None
The command completed successfully.

```

Figure 3: Local user detail review , confirming account status, password settings, and local group membership during IAM privilege validation.

- net localgroup administrators

```

PS C:\> net localgroup administrators
Alias name     administrators
Comment       Administrators have complete and unrestricted access to the computer/domain
Members
-----
Administrator
The command completed successfully.

```

Figure 4: Local Administrators group membership review confirming privileged accounts on IF-WIN-HP01 during post-removal IAM validation.

[Completed]

- Reboot validation stages
- Local user enumeration
- Local administrator verification
- Artifact collection/screenshots

Defender/security status check

- Security Posture Validation

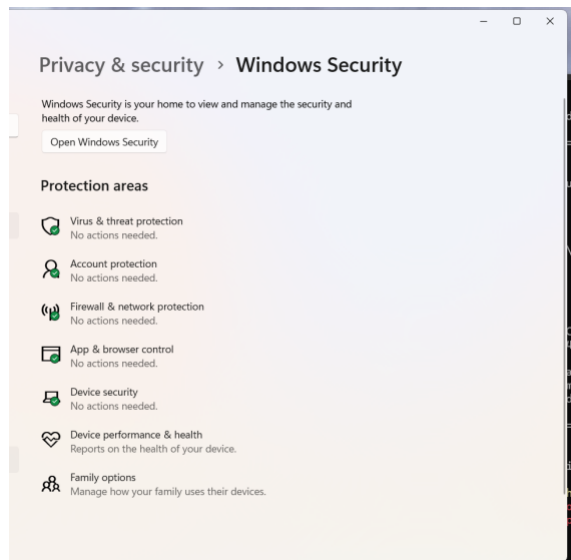


Figure 5: Windows Security dashboard showing primary protection areas reporting “No actions needed” after controlled network reconnection and security status validation.

Following application removal and reboot validation, security posture checks were performed to review Windows Security status, Defender status, local firewall profile configuration, update readiness, device rename confirmation, and future remote access planning.



Figure 6: Incorrect system time observed upon boot, showing the endpoint’s clock was not reliable for audit timestamping until corrected.

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Figure 7: Corrected system time captured after adjustment, supporting accurate artifact timestamps and audit reliability for continued hardening work.

Windows Defender

Defender status output

PowerShell

- Get-MpComputerStatus

```
AMEngineVersion      : 0.0.0.0
AMProductVersion     : 4.18.24050.7
AMRunningMode        : Not running
AMServiceEnabled     : False
AMServiceVersion     : 0.0.0.0
AntispywareEnabled   : False
AntispywareSignatureAge : 0
AntispywareSignatureLastUpdated :
```

Figure 8: Microsoft Defender status output captured with Get-MpComputerStatus, showing Defender antivirus/antispyware services not actively enabled at the time of review and supporting further validation of the active endpoint protection provider.

This result requires follow-up validation to confirm whether McAfee or another endpoint protection provider is serving as the active antivirus provider and whether Microsoft Defender is operating in passive/disabled mode.

Firewall

PowerShell

- Get-NetFirewallProfile

```
Name                : Domain
Enabled             : True
DefaultInboundAction : NotConfigured
DefaultOutboundAction : NotConfigured
AllowInboundRules    : NotConfigured
AllowLocalFirewallRules : NotConfigured
AllowLocalIPsecRules : NotConfigured
AllowUserApps        : NotConfigured
AllowUserPorts       : NotConfigured
AllowUnicastResponseToMulticast : NotConfigured
NotifyOnListen       : True
EnableStealthModeForIPsec : NotConfigured
```


Figure 9: Get-NetFirewallProfile output showing the Domain firewall profile enabled during post-hardening firewall posture validation.

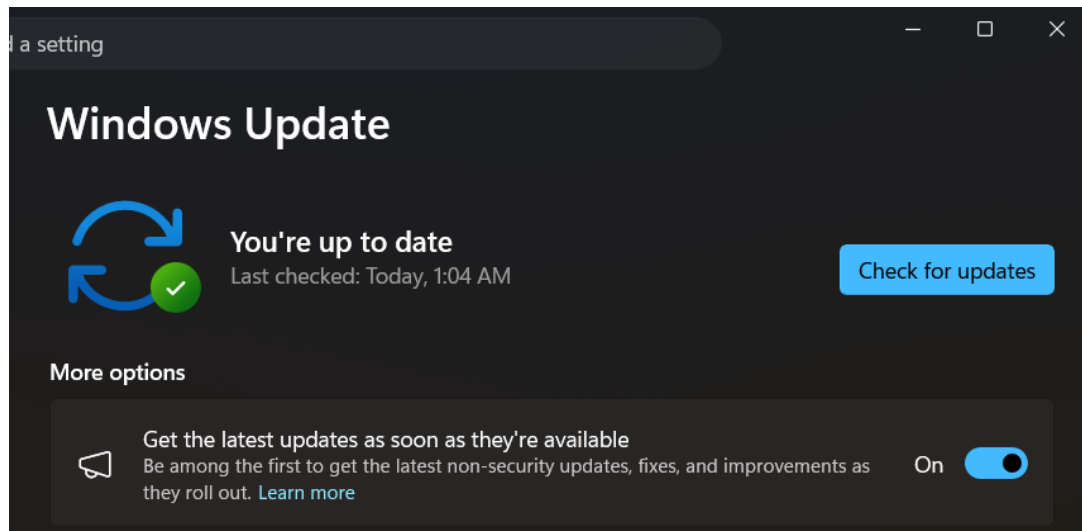


Figure 10: Windows Update validation showing IF-WIN-HP01 in an up-to-date state following Windows 11 version 24H2 installation, supporting post-hardening patch compliance verification.

Because Defender antivirus and antimalware services were not actively enabled in the Get-MpComputerStatus output, the active endpoint protection provider must be confirmed before this control can be considered fully validated.

Current Status and Remaining Actions

Completed:

- Offline IAM baseline captured and re-run after system time correction
- Endpoint renamed to IF-WIN-HP01
- Software inventory baseline generated
- Non-essential applications removed in two batches
- Reboot validation performed after application removals
- Local user and administrator group membership reviewed
- Windows Security dashboard validated with no actions needed
- Firewall profile status reviewed through PowerShell

Remaining:

- Confirm active endpoint protection provider and Microsoft Defender operating mode
- Confirm driver update status and complete final post-update validation

- Validate final installed application state after reboot
- Review BitLocker/encryption status
- Define remote access approach after baseline hardening is complete
- Maintain private evidence package separately from public redacted report

Conclusion / Closeout Status

The endpoint hardening review confirmed that IF-WIN-HP01 was renamed, baselined, updated, and reviewed against core local security controls. Offline IAM artifacts were captured and re-run after system time correction, non-essential applications were removed, local user and administrator group membership was reviewed, Windows Security status was inspected, firewall profile status was validated through PowerShell, and Windows Update was completed through the available Windows 11 version 24H2 update path.

At this checkpoint, the endpoint has reached a stable post-hardening state with Windows Update reporting the system as up to date. Remaining follow-up items include confirming the active endpoint protection provider, reviewing BitLocker/encryption status, validating final installed application state, and defining the remote access approach after baseline hardening is complete. This report should be treated as a post-hardening validation record and evidence package for the IF-WIN-HP01 endpoint.